

# Marketing Automation Blueprint

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## How to Build a System That Generates and Nurtures Leads Automatically

*A Practical Guide from Lake Tahoe Online (LTOL)*

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## Introduction

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Most small businesses have a collection of disconnected marketing tools: a website here, an email platform there, maybe a CRM that nobody fully uses. The result is leads falling through cracks, manual follow-ups that never happen, and marketing efforts that can't be measured.

Marketing automation connects these tools into a system that works while you sleep. It captures leads from your website, nurtures them with relevant content, scores them based on engagement, and alerts your sales team when someone is ready to buy.

This blueprint shows you exactly how to build that system — step by step, tool by tool, workflow by workflow.

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## Chapter 1: The Marketing Automation Stack

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A complete marketing automation system has five layers. You don't need to implement all five at once, but understanding the full picture helps you build in the right order.

### Layer 1: Lead Capture

**Purpose:** Convert anonymous website visitors into known contacts.

| Component         | What It Does                          | Examples                            |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Landing pages     | Focused pages designed for conversion | Service pages, resource downloads   |
| Forms             | Collect contact information           | Contact forms, newsletter signups   |
| Lead magnets      | Offer value in exchange for email     | Guides, checklists, assessments     |
| Chat widgets      | Engage visitors in real-time          | Live chat, chatbots                 |
| Pop-ups/slide-ins | Capture attention before exit         | Exit-intent offers, scroll triggers |

## Layer 2: Contact Management (CRM)

**Purpose:** Store, organize, and segment your contacts.

| Component         | What It Does                            | Why It Matters                  |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Contact records   | Central profile for each lead           | Single source of truth          |
| Custom fields     | Track business-specific data            | Segment by industry, size, need |
| Tags/lists        | Group contacts by behavior or attribute | Target messaging precisely      |
| Activity tracking | Log every interaction                   | Know where each lead stands     |
| Pipeline stages   | Track deal progression                  | Forecast revenue accurately     |

## Layer 3: Email Nurture

**Purpose:** Deliver the right message at the right time automatically.

| Component            | What It Does                       | When to Use                      |
|----------------------|------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Welcome sequences    | Introduce your brand to new leads  | Immediately after opt-in         |
| Nurture campaigns    | Educate and build trust over time  | Ongoing, behavior-triggered      |
| Re-engagement        | Win back inactive contacts         | After 30–90 days of silence      |
| Sales sequences      | Direct outreach to qualified leads | When lead score threshold is met |
| Transactional emails | Confirmations, receipts, updates   | After specific actions           |

## Layer 4: Lead Scoring

**Purpose:** Identify which leads are most likely to buy.

| Signal Type          | Examples                                 | Points                    |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| Demographic fit      | Right industry, company size, location   | +10 to +25                |
| Content engagement   | Downloads guide, reads 5+ blog posts     | +5 to +15 per action      |
| High-intent behavior | Visits pricing page, requests demo       | +20 to +50                |
| Email engagement     | Opens and clicks consistently            | +3 to +10 per interaction |
| Negative signals     | Unsubscribes, bounces, competitor domain | -10 to -50                |

## Layer 5: Analytics & Reporting

**Purpose:** Measure what’s working and optimize continuously.

| Metric                | What It Tells You                     | Target                |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| Lead-to-customer rate | Overall funnel efficiency             | 2–5% for B2B services |
| Email open rate       | Subject line and sender effectiveness | 25–40%                |
| Email click rate      | Content relevance and CTA strength    | 3–7%                  |
| Cost per lead         | Marketing efficiency                  | Varies by industry    |
| Time to conversion    | Sales cycle length                    | Track trend over time |

## Chapter 2: Website-to-CRM Lead Capture Workflow

This is the foundation of your automation system. Every form submission on your website should flow directly into your CRM with proper tagging and trigger the appropriate follow-up.

### The Workflow

```
Website Form Submitted
  ↓
Contact Created/Updated in CRM
  ↓
Tags Applied (source, interest, lead magnet)
  ↓
Welcome Email Sent (immediate)
  ↓
Nurture Sequence Triggered (based on interest)
  ↓
Lead Score Updated
  ↓
[If score threshold met] → Sales Alert
```

## Implementation Checklist

| Step | Action                                                   | Tools                  |
|------|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| 1    | Map all website forms to CRM fields                      | CRM + website platform |
| 2    | Create tags for each lead source and interest area       | CRM                    |
| 3    | Build welcome email template                             | Email platform         |
| 4    | Set up form submission trigger                           | Automation platform    |
| 5    | Test end-to-end (submit form → verify CRM → check email) | All                    |
| 6    | Monitor for errors weekly                                | CRM reports            |

## Field Mapping Example

| Website Form Field | CRM Field                | Notes                      |
|--------------------|--------------------------|----------------------------|
| Name               | First Name, Last Name    | Split on space             |
| Email              | Email                    | Primary identifier         |
| Phone              | Phone                    | Optional but valuable      |
| Company            | Company Name             | For B2B segmentation       |
| Service Interest   | Custom: Service Interest | Multi-select               |
| Source Page URL    | Custom: Lead Source Page | Track which page converted |
| UTM Parameters     | Custom: Campaign Source  | Track marketing channels   |

## Chapter 3: Email Nurture Sequence Templates

### Sequence 1: Welcome Series (5 emails over 14 days)

**Trigger:** New contact opts in via any form.

| Day | Subject Line Approach                   | Content Focus                             |
|-----|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| 0   | Welcome + deliver promised resource     | Set expectations, deliver value           |
| 2   | Your biggest challenge with [topic]     | Empathy + educational content             |
| 5   | How [similar business] solved [problem] | Social proof / case study                 |
| 9   | The one thing most businesses get wrong | Position expertise, challenge assumptions |
| 14  | Ready to talk? Here's how we can help   | Soft CTA to book a call                   |

## Sequence 2: Service-Specific Nurture (IT Services)

**Trigger:** Contact expresses interest in IT/managed services.

| Day | Subject Line Approach                                 | Content Focus       |
|-----|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|
| 0   | The hidden costs of reactive IT                       | Problem awareness   |
| 3   | What proactive IT management actually looks like      | Solution education  |
| 7   | Security risks you might be overlooking               | Urgency + expertise |
| 12  | How we helped [local business] reduce downtime by 80% | Case study          |
| 18  | Your technology is either helping or hurting growth   | Decision framing    |
| 25  | Let's look at your setup together (no obligation)     | Direct CTA          |

## Sequence 3: Re-Engagement (Inactive Contacts)

**Trigger:** No email opens or website visits in 60 days.

| Day | Subject Line Approach                       | Content Focus                    |
|-----|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| 0   | We noticed you've been quiet                | Acknowledge absence, offer value |
| 5   | Things have changed since we last connected | New content/services update      |
| 12  | Last chance: should we keep in touch?       | Clear opt-out option             |

# Chapter 4: Lead Scoring Model

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## Setting Up Your Scoring System

**Step 1:** Define your Ideal Customer Profile (ICP)

| Attribute        | Ideal                                           | Points |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------|--------|
| Company size     | 10–100 employees                                | +20    |
| Industry         | Professional services, healthcare, construction | +15    |
| Location         | Northern Nevada / Lake Tahoe region             | +10    |
| Decision-maker   | Owner, CEO, IT Director                         | +15    |
| Current IT setup | No managed provider                             | +10    |

**Step 2:** Assign engagement scores

| Action                         | Points | Decay            |
|--------------------------------|--------|------------------|
| Downloads a resource           | +10    | None             |
| Visits pricing/services page   | +20    | -5 after 30 days |
| Submits contact form           | +50    | None             |
| Opens email                    | +2     | Per email        |
| Clicks email link              | +5     | Per click        |
| Visits 5+ pages in one session | +15    | -5 after 14 days |
| Returns to site after 7+ days  | +10    | None             |

**Step 3:** Set thresholds

| Score Range | Status      | Action                                       |
|-------------|-------------|----------------------------------------------|
| 0–25        | Cold        | Continue nurture sequence                    |
| 26–50       | Warm        | Increase email frequency, add to retargeting |
| 51–75       | Hot         | Sales team alert, personal outreach          |
| 76+         | Sales-Ready | Immediate call, priority follow-up           |

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# Chapter 5: CRM Pipeline Design

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## Recommended Pipeline Stages

| Stage       | Definition                       | Exit Criteria                      |
|-------------|----------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| New Lead    | Just entered the system          | Qualified or disqualified          |
| Qualified   | Fits ICP, has expressed interest | Discovery call scheduled           |
| Discovery   | Initial conversation completed   | Proposal requested or declined     |
| Proposal    | Proposal/quote delivered         | Accepted or declined               |
| Negotiation | Terms being discussed            | Agreement reached                  |
| Closed Won  | Deal signed                      | Onboarding begins                  |
| Closed Lost | Deal declined                    | Reason documented, nurture resumed |

## Pipeline Hygiene Rules

- Leads without activity for 30 days get a status review
  - Every lead must have a next action date
  - Lost deals are tagged with a reason (price, timing, competitor, no decision)
  - Won deals trigger an onboarding workflow automatically
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# Chapter 6: Analytics & Reporting Setup

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## Weekly Dashboard Metrics

| Metric                | Source             | Goal                        |
|-----------------------|--------------------|-----------------------------|
| New leads this week   | CRM                | Track trend                 |
| Lead source breakdown | CRM + UTM tracking | Identify best channels      |
| Email performance     | Email platform     | Open rate > 25%, click > 3% |
| Website conversions   | Google Analytics   | Track conversion rate       |
| Pipeline value        | CRM                | Track growth                |

## Monthly Review Questions

1. Which lead source produced the most qualified leads?
  2. Which nurture sequence has the highest engagement?
  3. What’s our average time from lead to customer?
  4. Which content pieces drive the most conversions?
  5. Are there bottlenecks in our pipeline stages?
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# Chapter 7: Integration Checklist

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## Essential Integrations

| Connection           | Purpose                       | Priority |
|----------------------|-------------------------------|----------|
| Website → CRM        | Capture all form submissions  | Critical |
| CRM → Email platform | Trigger automated sequences   | Critical |
| Website → Analytics  | Track visitor behavior        | Critical |
| CRM → Calendar       | Enable self-service booking   | High     |
| Email → CRM          | Log all email activity        | High     |
| Social media → CRM   | Capture social leads          | Medium   |
| Phone system → CRM   | Log calls automatically       | Medium   |
| Accounting → CRM     | Track customer lifetime value | Low      |

## Integration Testing Protocol

For each integration, verify:

1. Data flows in the correct direction
2. Field mapping is accurate
3. Duplicate handling works properly
4. Error notifications are configured
5. A test record passes through successfully

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## Next Steps

1. **Take our free Marketing Systems Scorecard** at [ltol.com](https://ltol.com) to assess your current automation maturity.

2. **Book a Strategy Session** to design a marketing automation system tailored to your business.
3. **Start with Layer 1** — get your website forms flowing into a CRM before building anything else.

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